CHAPTER 39 Panchayati Raj

The term *Panchayati Raj* in India signifies the system of rural local self-government. It has been established in all the states of India by the Acts of the state legislatures to build democracy at the grass root level. It is entrusted with rural development. It was constitutionalised through the 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act of 1992.

In the scheme of division of powers between the Centre and the states in the Indian federal system, the item of 'local Government' is given to the states. Thus, the fifth entry of the State List of the Seventh Schedule to the Constitution of India deals with 'local government'.

Evolution of Panchayati Raj

 **Balwantrai Mehta Committee**

In January 1957, the Government of India appointed a committee to examine the working of the Community Development Programme (1952) and the National Extension Service (1953) and to suggest measures for their better working. The chairman of this committee was Balwantrai G Mehta. The committee submitted its report in November 1957 and recommended the establishment of the scheme of 'democratic decentralisation', which ultimately came to be known as Panchayati Raj. The specific recommendations made by it are:



1. Establishment of a three-tier panchayati raj system—gram panchayat at the village level, panchayat samiti at the block level and zila parishad at the district level. These tiers should be organically linked through a device of indirect elections.
2. The village panchayat should be constituted with directly elected representatives, whereas the panchayat samiti and zila parishad should be constituted with indirectly elected members.
3. All planning and development activities should be entrusted to these bodies.
4. The panchayat samiti should be the executive body while the zila parishad should be the advisory, coordinating and supervisory body.
5. The district collector should be the chairman of the zila parishad.
6. There should be a genuine transfer of power and responsibility to these democratic bodies.
7. Adequate resources should be transferred to these bodies to enable them to discharge their functions and fulfil their responsibilities.
8. A system should be evolved to effect further devolution of authority in future.